

Community Impact Grant 2026 — Funding Guidelines

Application Instructions, Program Standards, Eligibility Criteria & Submission Guidelines

KEY PROGRAM HIGHLIGHTS AT A GLANCE:

- **Grant Funding Range:** \$25,000 to \$100,000 per project award
- **Application Deadline:** September 30, 2026 at 5:00 PM Eastern Standard Time (EST)
- **Grant Term:** 12 Months (Project Period: January 1, 2027 – December 31, 2027)
- **Focus Areas:** Community learning, youth empowerment, digital inclusion, local skills development

1. Program Overview

The Northstar Community Foundation (NCF) is a regional philanthropic institution dedicated to fostering sustainable socio-economic progress, youth development, and educational enrichment. Through the 2026 Community Impact Grant program, NCF provides direct funding to community-based organizations executing projects that produce tangible, verifiable, and measurable benefits for local residents.

Grants awarded under this cycle range between **\$25,000 and \$100,000**. Proposals requesting funding outside this range will not be considered for evaluation. All proposed activities must be executed within the 12-month grant period beginning January 1, 2027.

Important Deadlines: Completed applications accompanied by all mandatory documentation must be submitted through the grant portal no later than **September 30, 2026 at 5:00 PM EST**. Late submissions will be rejected without review.

2. Mandatory Eligibility Requirements

To qualify for review and funding consideration, applicants must strictly satisfy all mandatory criteria established below. Failure to fulfill any mandatory requirement shall result in administrative disqualification.

REQ-001: Legal Nonprofit Status

Applicant must be a legally registered nonprofit organization in good standing with relevant state or federal authorities. Unincorporated community groups or for-profit entities are strictly ineligible.

REQ-002: Operating History

Applicant must have been operating for at least 2 years before the application deadline of September 30, 2026. The organization's legal registration or inception date must precede September 30, 2024.

REQ-003: Direct Community Benefit

The proposed project must directly benefit residents of the local community. Projects with purely administrative, research-only, or non-localized scope do not qualify.

REQ-004: Project Objectives

The application must clearly describe the project's objectives, outlining specific, measurable, and achievable milestones to be accomplished during the grant period.

REQ-005: Detailed Project Budget

The application must provide a detailed project budget showing all projected expenditures, category breakdowns, unit costs, and total funding allocations consistent with the requested grant amount.

2. Mandatory Eligibility Requirements (Continued)

REQ-006: Outcome Evaluation Methodology

The application must describe how project outcomes will be evaluated and measured, specifying objective performance indicators, data collection instruments, monitoring frequency, and target benchmarks.

REQ-007: Registration Certificate

A valid copy of the organization's legal registration certificate or official letter of incorporation must be provided as an official supporting document attachment.

REQ-008: Implementation Timeline

The applicant must identify the project implementation timeline, specifying key operational phases, quarterly target milestones, and program completion dates across the full funding cycle.

REQ-009: Target Beneficiary Population

The application must identify the specific population and community that will benefit from the project, detailing demographic characteristics, geographic boundaries, and estimated participation levels.

REQ-010: Key Project Activities

The applicant must describe key project activities in comprehensive operational detail, linking specific programmatic interventions directly to stated community outcomes.

3. Recommended and Optional Information

In addition to mandatory requirements, applicants are strongly advised to incorporate recommended supplementary materials. These items are not mandatory for administrative completeness, but they contribute substantially toward competitive scoring during peer committee review.

REQ-011: Letters of Community Support (RECOMMENDED)

Applicants are encouraged to provide letters of community support from local civic associations, community members, parent-teacher bodies, or neighborhood representatives endorsing the proposed initiative.

REQ-012: Evidence of Previous Project Outcomes (RECOMMENDED)

Applicants are encouraged to provide evidence of previous project outcomes, such as past program evaluation reports, pilot impact metrics, or verifiable historical data demonstrating organizational capacity.

REQ-013: Long-Term Sustainability Plan (RECOMMENDED)

Applicants are encouraged to describe long-term sustainability after grant funding ends, including diversified post-grant financing mechanisms, community ownership structures, and ongoing operational viability.

REQ-014: Partnerships and Collaborator Information (OPTIONAL)

Applicants may provide partnerships or collaborator information, including memorandums of understanding (MOUs) or letters of intent from formal implementation partners such as schools or municipal agencies.

4. Supporting Document Requirements

Applicants must assemble and upload supporting attachments alongside the primary grant narrative form. The following documentation guidelines govern document categorization and review standards:

Document Name	Requirement Status	Specifications & Purpose
Registration Certificate	REQUIRED (Mandatory)	Official state or national incorporation certificate verifying active nonprofit legal status. Required to substantiate REQ-001 and REQ-002.
Detailed Project Budget	REQUIRED (Mandatory)	Comprehensive line-item expenditure forecast matching requested grant funds (\$25,000–\$100,000). Required to substantiate REQ-005.
Previous Project Outcomes Report	RECOMMENDED	Documented results from prior community initiatives or pilot programs demonstrating delivery track record. Substantiates REQ-012.
Letters of Community Support	RECOMMENDED	Letters from local residents, neighborhood groups, or community beneficiaries expressing grassroots community endorsement. Substantiates REQ-011.
Partnership / Collaboration Letters	OPTIONAL	Formal commitments or letters of intent from partner schools, municipal facilities, or co-delivery institutions. Substantiates REQ-014.

5. Outcome Evaluation Methodology Standards

A rigorous, objective evaluation framework is critical to Northstar Community Foundation funding. To achieve a rating of 'Clearly Supported' on REQ-006, the applicant narrative must articulate:

- **Specific, Quantified Target Benchmarks:** Defining clear numerical targets for primary educational or community milestones.
- **Standardized Assessment Instruments:** Specifying validated pre- and post-intervention assessment tools, formal attendance records, or structured survey instruments.
- **Data Collection Frequency:** Establishing clear operational cadence (e.g., weekly tracking, monthly milestone audits, quarterly cumulative reviews).
- **Independent Verification:** Assigning designated evaluation personnel or external oversight to validate integrity of reported findings.

Note: Vague, aspirational statements such as 'monitoring feedback' or 'collecting informal responses' without quantitative metrics, timelines, or instruments will be deemed insufficient and evaluated as WEAK during completeness screening.

6. Grant Submission Checklist & Requirement Matrix

The following deterministic checklist establishes all 14 grant requirements, their contractual priority level, and the required verification source. Automated screening systems assess mandatory requirements (REQ-001 through REQ-010) to determine baseline application completeness.

Req ID	Requirement Description	Classification	Source Document
REQ-001	Legally registered nonprofit organization	REQUIRED	Application / Certificate
REQ-002	Minimum 2 years operating history prior to 09/30/2026	REQUIRED	Application / Certificate
REQ-003	Direct benefit to local community residents	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-004	Clearly described project objectives	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-005	Detailed project budget with line items	REQUIRED	Budget Attachment
REQ-006	Detailed outcome evaluation & measurement methodology	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-007	Valid official registration certificate copy provided	REQUIRED	Certificate Attachment
REQ-008	Project implementation timeline and phased schedule	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-009	Identification of target population & community served	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-010	Description of key operational project activities	REQUIRED	Application Narrative
REQ-011	Letters of community support from local residents	RECOMMENDED	Support Letters
REQ-012	Evidence of previous project outcomes & track record	RECOMMENDED	Previous Project Report
REQ-013	Long-term post-grant sustainability plan	RECOMMENDED	Application Narrative
REQ-014	Partnership agreements or institutional collaboration letters	OPTIONAL	Partnership Letters

7. Administrative Review & Governance Rules

Completeness Determination: Completeness scores are calculated deterministically across the 10 mandatory requirements (REQ-001 through REQ-010). Recommended and optional components are excluded from the mandatory completeness denominator.

Evidence Mapping Standards: Reviewers map evidence across narrative responses and primary attachments. Factual claims asserted in narrative responses must be substantiated by empirical data or official records. Unsupported claims will trigger formal reviewer clarification inquiries.

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